

would come as startling contentions peddled as certainties.

Hindu Bengali historians, litterateurs and even folk story tellers recall with utmost sadness the conquest of Bengal by seven Muslim horsemen at whose sight the Sena kings took flight. In all these years, I have yet to come across expressions of resentment against Maratha warriors except for one nursery rhyme that recalls the exorbitant demands for revenue by Burgees, a local name for disbanded Maratha hordes who spread in various directions after the Third Battle of Panipat. And is the Ramayana "denigrated" in the South? Barring the Dravida ideologue Periyar, there is hardly any other instance. The Kamban Ramayana is as revered in Tamil Nadu as Tulsidas's Ramcharitmanas in the North. And as for crossing the Indus, what about the great maritime conquests by the Chola Kings or the colonisation of Bali by traders from Orissa?

Turning to the period after Independence, the author's indulgence in the "ifs and buts" continues to amuse. His Counterfactual on the Emergency suggests that Indira Gandhi could have handed over office to Jagjivan Ram or Y.B. Chavan after the Allahabad High Court judgement unseating her for "they may have been willing to hand power back to her when she returned to the Lok Sabha". I am not suggesting Indira Gandhi should have imposed the Emergency, but how does Desai believe that her Cabinet colleagues would have handed power back to her? It is precisely insecurity that led her to impose dictatorship for she trusted none but her younger son—certainly not her own scheming partymen.

By this time, the author appears to have lost patience with his own narrative. His summary recollection of events leading to the 1977 elections and Janata experiment suffer from factual, not merely counterfactual, errors. He states that when asked to sever ties with the RSS, "Vajpayee refused and quit the Janata Party." Sorry Lord Desai, it wasn't quite so QED. He didn't quit. Morarji Desai's Government fell and the Jana Sangh component under Vajpayee went to the 1980 polls as the Janata Party with Chandra Shekhar as President. After the drubbing at the hustings, the Jana Sangh pulled out and formed the Bharatiya Janata Party.

As Desai gets into contemporary developments, his treatment of issues becomes increasingly cursory and hence pedestrian. In a bid to include every event, he skims over major developments that have shaped life and society in contemporary India—be it the Punjab insurgency, Mandal Report, Babri demolition, Kashmir imbroglio and so on. An intelligent newspaper reader would be able to reconstruct the history of the last 20 years with greater precision. This brings me back to my original query: Why was this book written and for whom? Lord Desai, a TV regular in India these days, should tell us one day why he took such pains to tell us all we already know and did not need to be reminded of. I learnt my history in my M.A. classes. Desai fails even to reinterpret history leave alone pompously undertake to rediscover India. ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. **2 States: The Story of My Marriage**
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. **The Lost Symbol**
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
3. **Five Point Someone**
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
4. **The Winner Stands Alone**
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
5. **The 3 Mistakes of My Life**
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

1. **Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight**
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
2. **Nine Lives: In Search of the Sacred in Modern India**
William Dalrymple, Bloomsbury
3. **Stay Hungry Stay Foolish**
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
4. **The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma**
Gurcharan Das, Penguin
5. **Superfreakonomics**
Steven D. Levitt and Stephen J. Dubner, Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

8. **The White Tiger**
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
11. **Slumdog Millionaire**
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan
12. **The Palace of Illusions: Panchaali's Mahabharat**
Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni, Picador

NON-FICTION

7. **The Professional**
Subroto Bagchi, Penguin
9. **Jinnah: India-Partition-Independence**
Jaswant Singh, Rupa
11. **A Better India A Better World**
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

For the complete list click to:
www.indiatoday.in

